Asking People Questions…?

Sociology 310 Discussions, Week 5

Peng, Haorui | October 2, 2026

Agenda

- Socially Desirability Bias (SDB)
- Surveys
- Interviews
- Preparation for Assignment #3
- Check Out

SDB and Ways to Reduce It

SDB

Definition and Causes

- People’s tendency to answer question in ways aligning with social norms and expectations
- Impression Management?
- Evolutionary Drive?
  - desire for social approval
  - need of safety (fear of getting into trouble)

Reducing SDB

i. Guarantee Confidentiality & Anonymity

- collect *only mandatory* identifying information → I assume ***there's none*** for you
  - this does not include demographic data
  - surveys - use case number as markers; restrict access to codebook for county/city names
  - interviews - use nicknames to specify respondents
- talk in private settings
- ensure that your participants are aware of you guaranteeing their confidentiality

Reducing SDB

ii. Be Neutral

- try, as much as possible, frame your questions as neutral
- this is hard, especially during interviews, but try it
  - react similarly, at least not differently, to all possible responses
    (e.g., some facial expressions may reflect your doubting/questioning?)

Reducing SDB

iii. Be Indirect / "Weaker"

- ask respondents how *other people* may behave / feel / think?
- use matter-of-fact tone/language, such that any answers feel not a big deal
- highlight that different people have different ways to answer
- point out certain choice(s) as normal or common

Survey*

*Thank to Michael Ybarra slides

Your Own, Small-Scale Survey

Structure

- Introduction
- Consent Form
- Instructions, including skipping logics
- Close-Ended + Partially Open-Ended Qs
- Fully Open-Ended Qs *for capturing additional information*

Your Own, Small-Scale Survey

Proxy

- An option if it’s hard to directly measure something
- education ← occupation ← income ← wealth
- rural / urban ← class / status

Your Own, Small-Scale Survey

Scale

- Likert Scale, e.g.,
  - Strongly Disagree
  - Somewhat Disagree
  - Neutral
  - Somewhat Agree
  - Strongly Agree

Your Own, Small-Scale Survey

Scale

- Likert Scale, e.g.,
  - From 1 (totally against) to 10 (totally for), what is your attitude towards … ?

Your Own, Small-Scale Survey

Scale

- Remember that **the order should be reasonable**
  - i.e., the variable being categorical-ordinal, numerical-interval, numerical-ratio
  - i.e., not nominal variables (college major, postal code, etc.)

Your Own, Small-Scale Survey

Index

- Created by add/subtracting/averaging multiple indicators
  not by multiplying!

- Consider your dimensions? Proxies?

Your Own, Small-Scale Survey

Index

- A personal critique of Pearlin et al. (1981)
  - maybe use either “reverse scored” or “forward scored”? don’t mix?

For the next set of statements, please think about whether you agree or disagree with the statement. For example, if the statement is extremely uncharacteristic of you, you may choose “Strongly Disagree.” On the other hand, if the statement is extremely characteristic of you, you may choose “Strongly Agree.” Use the options in the middle if you fall somewhere in between.

1. There's no way I can solve some of the problems I have.
2. Sometimes I feel that I am being pushed here and there in life.
3. I have little control over things that happen to me.
4. I can do anything when I put my mind to it.
5. Most of the time, I feel helpless when dealing with problems of life.
6. What happens to me in the future mostly depends on me.
7. There's little I can do to change most of the important things in my life.

A. Strongly disagree
B. Disagree
C. Somewhat disagree
D. Neither agree nor disagree
E. Somewhat agree
F. Agree
G. Strongly agree

Source: Pearlin Personal Mastery scale from Pearlin et al. (1981). Retrieved from Science of Behavior Change repository.

Scoring your result

Some items are reverse scored (R) and some are forward-scored (F)

1. **R:** There's no way I can solve some of the problems I have.
2. **R:** Sometimes I feel that I am being pushed here and there in life.
3. **R:** I have little control over things that happen to me.
4. F: I can do anything when I put my mind to it.
5. **R:** Most of the time, I feel helpless when dealing with problems of life.
6. F: What happens to me in the future mostly depends on me.
7. **R:** There's little I can do to change most of the important things in my life.

Response	Forward score (F)	Reverse score (R)
A	1	7
B	2	6
C	3	5
D	4	4
E	5	3
F	6	2
G	7	1

“Score ranges from 7 to 49. Higher scores reflect greater levels of mastery.”

Source: Pearlin Personal Mastery scale from Pearlin et al. (1981). Retrieved from Science of Behavior Change repository.

Your Own, Small-Scale Survey

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- Another Example: U.S. News National University Ranking

National Universities 2027 Best Colleges Overall Ranking Criteria and Weights

Indicator	2027 National Universities Weight for Schools With Usable SAT/ACT	2027 National Universities Weight for Schools Without Usable SAT/ACT
Graduation rates	16%	21%
First-year retention rates	5%	5%
Graduation rate performance	10%	10%
Pell graduation rates	5.5%	5.5%
Pell graduation performance	5.5%	5.5%
College grads earning more than a high school grad	5%	5%
Earnings by major	5%	5%
Peer assessment	20%	20%
Financial resources	8%	8%
Faculty salaries	6%	6%
Faculty who are full-time	2%	2%
Student-faculty ratio	3%	3%
Standardized tests	5%	0%
Citations per publication	1.25%	1.25%
Field-Weighted Citation Impact	1.25%	1.25%
Publication share in the Top 5% of Journals by CiteScore	1%	1%
Publication share in the Top 25% of Journals by CiteScore	0.5%	0.5%
TOTAL	100%	100%

Your Own, Small-Scale Survey

Your Variables…

- IV & DV
- Mediators, Moderators, Confounders
- Controls/Covariates
  - to see influences/impacts net of these

Your Own, Small-Scale Survey

Guidelines for Asking Questions

- Choose appropriate question / statement forms
- Short items are the best
- Make items clear and precise
- Use clear and simple language
- Avoid biased items and terms
- Place choices in a reasonable order

Your Own, Small-Scale Survey

Guidelines for Asking Questions

- Questions should be relevant and should generate variation among responses
- Be respectful to your respondents' time - limit the total number of items
- Respondents must be willing to answer. So beware of sensitive questions and socially acceptable answers

Your Own, Small-Scale Survey

Issues around Stating Questions

- Negative and Double Negatives
  - To what extent do you agree with this statement?
    We should not reduce the number of options in our product.
    → strongly agree / agree / neutral / disagree / strongly disagree
- Double-Barreled
  - In your opinion, how would you rate the speed and usefulness of our service response?
    → excellent / good / fair / poor

Your Own, Small-Scale Survey

Issues around Stating Questions

- Leading Question
  - How did our amazing customer support team perform today?
    → excellent / good / fair / poor
- Loaded Terms (words with negative or positive associations)
  - ~~Are you pro-life?~~
  - Rather, “Please tell me whether or not you think it should be possible for a pregnant woman to obtain a legal abortion if …” as in General Social Survey.

Your Own, Small-Scale Survey

Issues around Stating Questions

- Threatening Questions on Sensitive Topics
  - those about illegal actions?
- Questions eliciting socially desirable responses
- Place them at the end - build trust first!

Your Own, Small-Scale Survey

Samples?

- General Social Survey
  - 2006 version may be the most recent and human-readable
- China Family Panel Study (equivalent to PSID)
  - 2022 version is the most recent

Interviews*

*Thank to Renee Anspach slides

In-Depth Interviews

Structure

- collection of necessary socio-demographic information ↔ your potential covariates?
  note: may also be at the end; depend on how you organize (pre-survey + interview?)
- Theme 1
  - Major Question 1
    - Probe Question 1
    - Probe Question 2
  - Major Question 2
- (and you repeat…)

In-Depth Interviews

Strategies - What's Covered in Lecture

- ask one question at a time
- listen more than you talk
- don't argue, correct, or fact-check
- show engagement without leading
- be flexible with your wording
- seek out specifics / avoid generalities
- don't ask your actual RQ

In-Depth Interviews

DOs and DON'Ts - Question Ordering

- e.g., influences of heights on people's lives
- Follow an Orderly Progression
  - Do you find yourself comparing to others based on height? In what scenarios do these comparisons occur?
  - Do people ever make comments about your height? How do these comments make you feel?
  - Have you ever been treated with growth hormones?

In-Depth Interviews

DOs and DON'Ts - Question Ordering

- e.g., influences of heights on people's lives
- Chronological Order
  - perception of general attitudes toward short people
  - childhood & adolescence (family, friends, school)
  - impact of height on adult social activities (meeting new people, romantic relationships)
  - scenario: strategies for managing typical meeting
  - overall assessment of impact of height on life

In-Depth Interviews

DOs and DON'Ts - Question Ordering

- e.g., influences of heights on people's lives
- Consider whether respondents have had some opinions
  - If yes, use a funnel sequence, moving from general to specific Qs
    e.g., general attitudes → their own situation → specific experiences
  - If not, use an inverted funnel sequence, moving from specific to general Qs

In-Depth Interviews

DOs and DON'Ts - Question Ordering

- Place more threatening and/or more personal questions at the end
- Move from general/nonthreatening Qs to personal Qs
- e.g.,
  - Would you say the Chicago library facilities in your neighborhood are good, fair, or poor?
  - Does anyone in your family have a library card?
  - Do you have your own Chicago public library card?

In-Depth Interviews

DOs and DON'Ts - Question Wording

- don't use leading questions
  - *leading* -
    The US Supreme Court has ruled … . Do you favor or oppose this ruling?
  - *somewhat leading* -
    How does your height affect your relationship with those people you're attracted to?
    Do you think you were treated differently because of your height?
  - *less leading* -
    Do you think you were treated differently because of your height, or were you treated in about the same way?

In-Depth Interviews

DOs and DON'Ts - Question Wording

- don't use double-barreled questions
  - e.g.,

    Are you in favor of building more power plants so that we can have enough electricity to meet the country's needs, or are you opposed to more nuclear power plants even though that would mean less electricity?

    Do you ever feel invisible, or feel that people have no respect for your personal space?

In-Depth Interviews

DOs and DON'Ts - Question Type/Function

- don't use restrictive elicitations, including
- Yes / No Questions
  - Do teachers favor certain students?

In-Depth Interviews

DOs and DON'Ts - Question Type/Function

- don't use restrictive elicitations, including
- Yes / No Questions
  - ~~Do teachers favor certain students?~~
    Some people say teachers favor certain students, while others say students are treated in the same way. Can you tell me about that?

In-Depth Interviews

DOs and DON'Ts - Question Type/Function

- don't use restrictive elicitations, including
- Yes / No Questions
  - ~~Do teachers favor certain students?~~
    Some people say teachers favor certain students, while others say students are treated in the same way. Can you tell me about that?
- Requests for Confirmation
  - So abortion is taking human life?

In-Depth Interviews

DOs and DON'Ts - Question Type/Function

- don't use restrictive elicitations, including
- Yes / No Questions
  - ~~Do teachers favor certain students?~~
    Some people say teachers favor certain students, while others say students are treated in the same way. Can you tell me about that?
- Requests for Confirmation
  - ~~So abortion is taking human life?~~
    note: may work only as probes

In-Depth Interviews

DOs and DON'Ts - Question Type/Function

- don't use restrictive elicitations, including
- Tag Questions
  - Poor people are no more lazy than middle-class Americans, right?
- Forced or Fixed Choice Questions
  - Do you rent or do you own your own home?
  - Did you become a doctor by choice or by any chance?

In-Depth Interviews

DOs and DON'Ts - Question Type/Function

- do use non-restrictive elicitations, such as
  - How did you become a college professor?
  - How do you feel about the case?
  - What kind of future do you think this patient will have?
- *Note: when necessary, may use restrictive elicitations to probe for more specific information*

In-Depth Interviews

DOs and DON'Ts - Probe

- do probe for what the respondent means. e.g.,
- continuation, to encourage respondents to keep talking
  - Q: What are the most important problems facing the nation today?
  - A: I don't know. There are so many.
  - Q: That's right. I'd just like to know what you think are the most important problems.
  - A: Well, there's certainly inflation. …

In-Depth Interviews

DOs and DON'Ts - Kinds of Probes

- do probe for what the respondent means. e.g.,
- clarification, to ask respondents to explain something ambiguous or unclear
  - A: Well, there's certainly inflation, and then government spending.
  - Q: Government spending? Could you please explain a bit more?
  - A: There's no end in sight. The war, welfare, …

In-Depth Interviews

A Sample?

Engquist, Ella B. 2024. "*'Bless Me Father, for I Have Sinned': (Re)Constructing Catholic Confession through Embodied Experiences.*" BA senior thesis, Department of Sociology, University of Michigan. Ann Arbor, MI.

- Appendices A-C (pp. 120-130), especially **Appendix C (pp. 123-130)**
- 2023-24 Cohort, Robert Cooley Angell Award (best thesis)
- File on Canvas or via this link

For Assignment #3

For Assignment #3

as a low-stake practice / a beginning point

- choose (one of) your most complex concept(s)
- think about how you want to collect information for this concept
  - index/proxy → questions to ask survey respondents?
  - major questions under this theme, and potential probes, for interviewees?

Check Out

- Please fill in this Check Out Form before you leave
- I will be using this form to track your attendance. This form is also a place where you can share your thoughts, questions, concerns, etc. You can also share your suggestions on how I can improve our sections.
- https://forms.gle/PwzV7cHZdkVabXb77

